Introduction to the Prophets

More books in the Old Testament come under the category of prophecy than any other category. The prophets are divided into 2 groups: the Major Prophets (Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Daniel) and Minor Prophets: (the last 12 books of the OT). (Note: The terms "major" and "minor" do not imply anything about the importance or content of the book, just the length.)

Who were the Prophets:

A prophet may be defined as *a spokesman of God's special revelation*; and prophecy, in its broadest sense, as simply *the message of a prophet*. [1]

One trait characterized them all: a faithful proclamation of God's Word and not their own. (Jer 23.16 / Ezk 13.2)

Call of the Prophets: A prophet received his call directly from God. Their ministry was not inherited or passed through family lines, but they were appointed to the ministry by God. Prophets included:

- Shepherds and Farmers: Elisha, Amos
- Youth: Jeremiah
- Priests: Ezekiel
- Women: Huldah

Nature & Function of the Prophets:

1. Enforcers of the Covenant.

- The prophets can be compared to law enforcement officers. The prophets enforced God's Law – their main job was calling people back to the Covenant.
- A true prophet is one who affirms the Law of God.

2. God's Spokesmen.

- Brought God's Word to their contemporary situation.
- Note the repeated phrase throughout the Prophets, "Thus says the LORD", or "says the LORD." The prophets' message was not their own, but *God's* message to the people. [Eg Jer 27-28]

True or False? The following distinguishes between true & false prophets ✍.

The Three Tests of a True Prophet:

1. *Theological Test:* Is the prophet doctrinally sound? → Dt 13.1-11
2. *Practical Test:* Do the prophet's words come to pass? → Dt 18.20
3. *Moral Test:* Is the prophet of godly character? → Jer 23.9,13-23

[1] Definitions from Payne, p.4

3. Teaching

1. Teaching with the goal of moral reformation. Their message was not a new one but their cry was to remember the covenant.
2. Called the people to repentance.
3. Overall message:
   - God rules history. Is. 6:1-4
   - The greatness of God verses the sinfulness of man. Jer. 3:11
   - The need to get right with God. Is. 30:15-18
   - Return to the moral foundations of the covenant. Jer. 7:1-15

     Result: Judgement: when covenant is broken

     Blessing: Restoration - physical

     - spiritual (Messianic)
4. Major Theme: SIN => JUDGEMENT => RESTORATION
5. Spoke of Israel's past, present & future

   Past:
   - What God has done for them throughout history, His powerful acts, reminder of His goodness.
   - Sins their fathers have walked in, how they've gone astray.

   Present:
   - Religious situation: idolatry, hearts far from God…
   - Social situation: injustice, oppression, moral rottenness
   - Political situation: corruption, trusting in themselves & other nations rather than God …
   - Facing God's judgment because of their sin

   Future:
   - Judgment – because of sin
   - Hope (Restoration) – because of God's goodness & mercy

"Prophecy is not just information about future events,
but God's method of changing human thinking and behavior
through a deeper understanding of His mighty acts in the past, present, and future." [2]

4. Predictive - a statement about the future that is beyond the power of human knowledge to discern, calculate, or bring to pass.

Percentage of Predictive Prophecy in the Bible: [3]

- At least 27% of the Bible is predictive. (predictive at the time of the prophet)
- 28% of the OT is predictive.
- 21% of the NT is predictive.
- Less than 2% is Messianic.
- less than 5% describes the New Covenant.
- less than 1% describes the 2nd Coming.

1. Predictions for the future are designed not to satisfy the curiosity of people but to serve as leverage to bring people to repentance - back to the covenant. Jer. 22:1-7

[2] G.V. Smith. *International Standard Encyclopedia of the Bible.* "Prophet", p.1002
[3] The first three statistics are from Payne, the last three from Fee & Stuart, p.166

2. Predictions also stabilize the faith of the true believers and lift them out of their grim circumstances by focusing on the blessings. Especially the blessing of physical restoration or the age to come.
3. Short range - were fulfilled in their lifetime. Is. 8:1-4
    - Israel & Judah's Exile
    - Judgement on the surrounding nations
    - Physical restoration - return from exile

   Long range - normally look to the Messianic age. Is 9:1-7
    - Spiritual restoration - during the Messianic Kingdom. This includes the time between Jesus' first & second coming and then ultimately in the age to come. (The now & not yet.)
    - Josiah's name & ministry was prophesied 308 years in advance. 1 Kings 13:2
    - Daniel prophesies the specifics of the Persian Empire => the Greek Empire => the Roman Empire => JESUS
4. Confirms the word of the Prophet
    - Jeremiah's prediction of Hananiah's death. Jer. 28:5-17 He died 3 months later. Verse 9 shows they should now listen.
5. Brings glory to God, reveals his wisdom, sovereignty & authority:
    - The future is beyond the power of human knowledge.
    - Distinguishes Him above the idols.
6. Everything has come to pass except:_____
7. They are not to be used as a side-by-side commentary with 21st century newspapers. They had a specific audience at a specific time

The prophets saw the mountain peaks of prophetic events, but not the valleys of time in between. [IBD]

The prophets focused on the reality of their prophecies and not the time of their fulfillment. In their minds their prophecies were already accomplished, primarily because they knew God was in charge of history. [IBD]

In summary, the message of the prophets is one of judgment and hope: judgment for those who ignore social justice and who corrupt religious activity, but hope for the little remnant which is faithful to the standards of the Lord's covenant. The future, like the past, is an integral part of their message, because only a God who controls the future and is guiding it to His own consummation can effectively warn of judgment or realistically offer hope. [4]

Communicating the Message:

1. Spoken messages.

2. Enacted Symbols: Sometimes a prophet acted out his message symbolically.

- Isaiah went naked and barefoot for 3 years -- symbolizing … (Is 20)
- Hosea married a prostitute – showing Israel her relationship with God was like that of an unfaithful wife to a faithful husband.
- Ezekiel lay on his side for over a year and ate his food baked over dung…

[4] Armerding, *A Guide to Biblical Prophecy*, p.67-68

Purpose:

These symbolic acts were designed to capture the attention of an audience whose hearts were hardened and who refused to listen to the prophet's verbal messages.

3. **Written messages.** Such as on a scroll.